The Connected Firm

Project outline and business case: an events strategy for White & Case's New York office

Prepared by Sofia Mota | October 30, 2026 | Built from public sources. Sources are dated and assumptions are labeled. Illustrative figures are scenarios, not promises.

> *"White & Case already runs great events. I'd help connect them into one system and measure what they achieve, starting with the lateral partners the 2028 plan depends on."*
>
> *"I'd handle the logistics like any coordinator, and I'd also measure what each event achieves, so the team can show leadership exactly how events support the 2028 plan."*

Site structure

- **Main page, in scroll order:** 0 Opening, 1 Why now, 2 The problem (research), 3 What White & Case people say, 4 What already exists (with the London callout), 5 The plan, 6 The business case (with calculator), 7 How I'd measure it, 8 Risks I'd plan for, 9 About me and contact.
- **Clickable pages:** Culture Extras, Methodology and assumptions, Sources.

1. Why now: White & Case's moment

Visual: four number tiles plus a small bar chart of top-10 firm growth.

Fact	Figure	Note
2025 revenue	$3.594bn, up ~8.4%	Am Law: 8.36%; firm: 8.5%
Big Law average growth, 2025	~13%	Wells Fargo, via Bloomberg Law
2028 revenue goal	Over $5bn	Firm's "2028 strategy"
Growth needed to hit $5bn	11.6% a year	(5 / 3.594)^(1/3) - 1 = 11.63%
2028 revenue at current pace	$4.57-4.59bn	3.594 x 1.0836^3 = 4.573; 3.594 x 1.085^3 = 4.591
Shortfall vs $5bn	~$410-430M	My calculation
Lateral partners hired, 2025	51	Across 43 offices in 29 countries
Equity partners	349 to 332 (-4.9%)	After -7% in 2024
Cross-border work	About half of revenue	Firm statement

2. The problem: what research says

New partners

- **30-38%** of lateral partners leave within five years (Decipher, cited by Above the Law, 2026). Older studies found up to 47%, so this range is conservative.
- About **$4,039,200** per failed lateral partner at an Am Law 50 firm (Decipher, about 2022).
- Effective integration is the single best predictor of lateral success (Major, Lindsey & Africa, 2020).
- 85% of firms do not track whether lateral hires succeed (Nexl, 2026).

People

- **61%** of lawyers scored above average on the UCLA loneliness scale, the highest of any profession studied (Harvard Business Review, 2018).
- **Gallup, 2022:** 37% of employees with a best friend at work were willing to leave, versus 49% without one. Only 2 in 10 US employees have a best friend at work.
- **SHRM, October 2026:** 18% of workers satisfied with their sense of belonging seriously considered quitting, versus 61% of those dissatisfied (5,107 workers, 26 countries).
- **Field experiment:** offices given small budgets for social activities saw turnover fall 4-5 points (RFBerlin; a microfinance company, not a law firm).
- **$200,000-$500,000** to replace one associate (NALP, 2017; likely conservative today).
- Associate attrition reached about **20%** in 2024 (LeanLaw).
- Only **9.4%** of associates are in it for the money alone, down from 17.2% in 2022 (BTI, 2026). After pay, associates rank culture (69%) and quality of work (64%) as reasons to stay (Major, Lindsey & Africa).

3. What White & Case people say

Use summary figures only. No individual review quotes and no identifying details.

Measure	Figure	Source
Overall rating	3.9 / 5, 75% would recommend	Glassdoor, 601 reviews
Strongest category	Compensation and benefits 4.3	Glassdoor
Weakest category	Work-life balance 3.4 (7% below similar legal employers)	Glassdoor, Sept 2026
New York	3.8; best-rated US office found; 62% would recommend	Glassdoor, 126 reviews (verify)
By role	Legal Assistants 4.7 vs Practice Assistants 3.5	Glassdoor

Framing: "People praise their colleagues. The opportunity is making that experience consistent across every team and office."

4. What already exists, and the gaps

Exists	Possible gap	What I'd add
Momentum summits (3rd- and 5th-year associates)	Connections can fade between yearly summits	Momentum Circles
~50 lateral partners a year	No public sign of a structured welcome program	**First 90 Days** (lead)
43 offices, ~50% cross-border work	Office ties depend on individual deals	Global Table
Client events	Usually measured by attendance	Client Roundtables

Proven inside White & Case: London

• Quarterly team socials, office-wide events, a local bar with a White & Case discount, a free in-house restaurant (Broad St Kitchen), and supervisor and buddy lunches for newcomers.

• Junior lawyers grade London's social life A to A* and peer support A* (Legal Cheek survey).

• Lesson for New York: put socializing on a predictable calendar, use the cafeteria as a hub, give every newcomer a buddy.

• Honest caveat: London still grades C on work-life balance. Connection helps people stay; it does not fix long hours.

5. The plan: a one-year New York pilot

Program	Calculation	Cost
First 90 Days (lead)	~15 NY partners* x 3 lunches x 6 people x $100	$27,000
Momentum Circles	4 cohorts x 12 people x 10 lunches x $40	$19,200
Global Table	2 mixers x 60 people x $75 (virtual sessions ~free)	$9,000
Client Roundtables	8 dinners x 14 seats x $200	$22,400
Total		**$77,600 (~$78K)**

*My estimate. White & Case does not publish lateral hires by office. NYC corporate dinners typically run $75-$200 per person (Naboo, 2026).

- **Leaner option:** at Arnold & Porter's $50-per-person lunch limit, First 90 Days costs $13,500 and the total drops to ~$64K.
- **Cost-neutral option:** one 200-person reception (200 x $150 = $30,000) pays for about 10 client dinners ($30,000 / $2,800 = 10.7).
- **Roadmap:** Month 1 listen and set baselines; Months 2-3 launch First 90 Days and Momentum Circles; Months 4-6 add Client Roundtables and Global Table; Months 7-12 compare participants with non-participants and recommend scale, adjust or stop.
- **Design rule:** every program is optional, small and short. Mandatory team-building can backfire.

6. The business case (illustrative scenarios)

Lateral partners

- 51 x 30% = **15.3** and 51 x 38% = **19.4** partners from one year of hiring likely to leave within five years.
- x $4,039,200 = **$61.8M-$78.3M** at risk.
- Firmwide First 90 Days: 51 x 3 x 6 x $100 = **$91,800**.
- Saving **one** partner saves $4,039,200 / $91,800 = **44x the cost**. That moves the failure rate by just 1 / 51 = 2 points.

"Keep 4 people from leaving"

Who	Calculation	Saved
4 associates (low)	4 x $200,000	$800,000

Who	Calculation	Saved
4 associates (high)	4 x $500,000	$2,000,000
4 lateral partners	4 x $4,039,200	~$16.2M

Keeping 4 associates returns 10-26x the $77,600 pilot cost.

Associates (Momentum Circles, 48 people)

- Cautious: 48 x 1% = 0.48 departures avoided x $200,000 = **$96,000**, or **5x** the $19,200 cost.
- Field-experiment result: 48 x 4% = 1.92 x $200,000 = **$384,000**, or **20x**.

Clients

- Clients served by three practice groups generate 5.7x the revenue of clients served by one (Heidi Gardner, Harvard).
- Clients spend about twice as much with firms that ask for formal feedback, yet only 27% are asked (Thomson Reuters).
- Break-even: $1.36M revenue per lawyer / 250 working days = $5,440 a day; $22,400 / $5,440 = **about 4 days** of one lawyer's work in new business.

Headline numbers

- $77,600 / $4,039,200 = 1.9%. The whole pilot costs less than 2% of one failed lateral partner.
- Calculator default: 1,950 non-partner lawyers x 1 point x $200,000 = $3.9M, or ~50x the pilot cost.

7. How I'd measure it (analytics)

- Set success targets before launch (for example, 10+ cross-office introductions per new partner in 90 days).
- Link event attendance to the firm's client and new-work data.
- Publish a monthly Event Impact Scorecard: attendance, repeat rate, follow-ups within 30 days, new matters, cost per relationship, belonging score.
- Compare participants with similar non-participants, with surveys before and after.
- Map relationships to flag new partners with few connections at day 30 (anonymized totals only).
- Track no-show rates and cost per guest to cut waste.
- Analyze client feedback themes in English and Portuguese.
- Add one survey question: "I feel valued for my work."

8. Risks I'd plan for

Pushback	Answer
"We already do this."	It builds on Momentum, the alumni program and client events, and supports the HR and talent teams that own retention.
"Lawyers won't show up."	Optional, small and short: lunch or 90 minutes in the evening.
"You can't prove it."	True in year one. Track early signals, then compare participants with non-participants.
"Costs are already up."	Use the cost-neutral version: move budget from one large reception.

Pushback	Answer
"Partners won't host."	Hosting supports the new partner evaluations, which reward client engagement and collaboration.
Privacy and compliance	Anonymized reporting only, HR and compliance sign-off, and client gift rules respected.

9. About me and contact

Sofia Mota, 2026 Business Analytics graduate of Biola University. Events Coordinator for Biola's Global Student Engagement office (about 10 events a semester). Coordinated camps for 200+ kids and built dashboards with Restoration Ministries in Sao Paulo. Speaks English and Portuguese. sofiamotaus@gmail.com

Clickable page: Culture Extras

What other firms do

- **O'Melveny** (No. 1 on Vault's Best Law Firms to Work For): every new associate gets a partner mentor and an associate mentor; the firm sponsors coffee and lunch so everyone can meet.
- **Arnold & Porter:** unlimited free lunch with new associates for their first three months ($50 per person limit), plus a mentorship lunch budget.
- **Fried Frank:** introduced free "grab and go" lunches on "Reconnect Wednesdays" (about 2022; describe as past).
- **Ropes & Gray:** complimentary breakfast and lunch in the office.
- **Baker Donelson:** BakerWell wellness program with coaching and mental health resources.

What White & Case already has

- The annual "World Cup" inter-office football and volleyball tournament (Madrid 2024, Munich 2025).
- A full-service cafeteria in the New York office; Broad St Kitchen in London serving free meals.
- The London socials described in the callout on page 3.

Ideas

- **Closing Bell:** extend closing celebrations to everyone who worked the deal, including paralegals, assistants and business services staff.
- **Connect Table:** a weekly cafeteria lunch where people from different practices and roles sit together on purpose.
- **Lunch Roulette:** random pairings across practices, offices and roles for a sponsored coffee.
- **Seen Awards:** peer-nominated recognition read aloud at a monthly gathering.
- **Skills Swap:** staff teach lawyers a skill and lawyers teach staff how a deal works.
- **Taste of 29 Countries:** a monthly food or culture hour hosted by one office's country.
- **Pro Bono Team Day** and **Partner Office Hours**.
- **Thursday Table guidelines:** HR approval, licensed bartender, strong non-alcoholic options, a set end time, no open tabs paid by senior people for junior people.

Clickable page: Methodology and assumptions

Assumption	Value used	Why
NY lateral partners per year	~15	My estimate; not published by office
Lunch cost per person	$100 ($50 lean)	Estimate; Arnold & Porter caps at $50
Client dinner per person	$200	NYC range $75-$200 (Naboo, 2026)
Turnover reduction	1-4 points	Field experiment found 4-5 points (non-legal firm)
Cost per associate departure	$200,000-$500,000	NALP, 2017
Cost per failed lateral partner	$4,039,200	Decipher, about 2022
Working days per year	250	Standard assumption

Still to verify before publishing

- New York Glassdoor figures (Glassdoor's own summary text is inconsistent).
- Whether Fried Frank still runs Reconnect Wednesdays.
- Whether White & Case has an internal lateral welcome program (ask in conversations).
- All About me details.

Clickable page: Sources

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